



How to use Information Classification Labels

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Introduction

What are Information Classification Labels?

The Information classification labels in Microsoft Office applications (also known as "sensitivity labels" in case you see that term anywhere) are a feature built into Microsoft Office and other tools that can be used to support and enhance data classification. In simple terms, think of them as digital tags that you can apply to documents and files depending on how you want to classify the information.

These labels help you quickly and easily identify the classification and sensitivity of the information, supporting your decisions on how to handle that information.

Not only do they provide a visual classification, but they also apply a set of technical policies and controls to automatically help Colleagues comply with the Bank's Data Classification standards. For example, a document labelled **Amber/Protected** will automatically be encrypted.

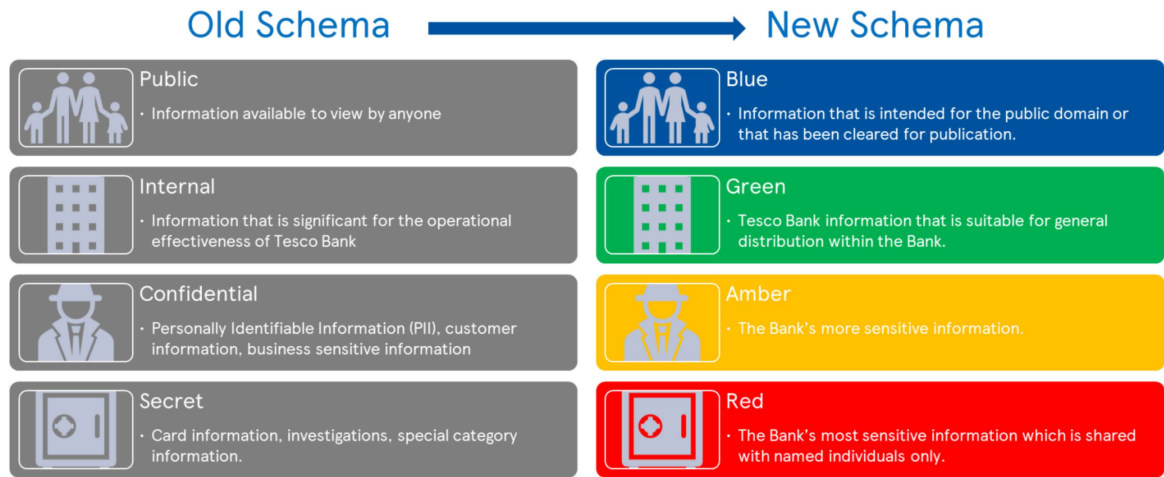
The protection travels with the document. Classification labels will work in conjunction with Data Loss Prevention Policies to help prevent unauthorised sharing of data, helping the Bank to remain safe and compliant.

Information Classification Framework

The below table summarises the new information classification standard for confidentiality that has recently been deployed across the Bank. For a full explanation of the new Information Classification Framework please see the [Mandatory Information Classification Requirements](#).

Moving to a new Classification Schema.

Based on the model the Bank of England used, which uses colours



Confidentiality	Description
Blue	Information that is intended for the public domain or that has been cleared for publication. This is information for consumption by anyone inside and outside the Bank. Information Classified as Blue can be discussed and shared without restrictions whether verbally, or in digital or physical format
Green	Tesco Bank information that is suitable for general distribution within the Bank. Information classified as Green is suitable for general distribution within the Bank
Amber	The Bank's more sensitive information. The information may be market sensitive, may include personal information, may relate to colleagues or customers, and may be subject to legal professional privilege. All Personal Identifiable Information must be classified Amber except where this is protected characteristic information. (See definition of Red).
Red	The Bank's most sensitive information which is shared with named individuals only. The information may be market sensitive or impact the market, it may include protected characteristic personal information, or be subject to legal professional privilege. These may be assets that the bank is required to keep to a strictly limited number of individuals by law or regulatory requirement. These assets include those that affect the long-term strategic effectiveness of Tesco Bank. This information must not be shared beyond those with a legitimate need, and where failure to maintain secrecy is likely to result in significant repercussions including organisational or personal legal, regulatory and/or legislative sanctions.

When Green, Amber or Red information is shared either with established trusted third-parties, or with others, there must be a business justification.

Label Overview

The below labels have been created to support the new Information Classification Standard, and apply some security controls in the background. This makes it easy for Colleagues to make sure information is protected properly, and also provide convenient actions like applying an automatic footer indicating the classification.

There are essentially two labels per information classification:

The “**Protected**” label - this label applies encryption to documents and emails, and stamps the relevant classification in a footer.

The “**Unprotected**” label - this label does not apply encryption. This simply stamps the relevant classification in a footer.

Blue classification is the exception to this, which only has the “unprotected” label as this information classification does not require protection.

Red

Unprotected - This label applies a footer of “Data Classification: Red”

Protected - This label applies encryption and a footer of “Data Classification: Red”

Restricted - This label is for those rare occasions when you want to be very restrictive and prevent recipients from forwarding and printing emails or apply specific permissions on documents.

Amber

Unprotected - This label applies a footer of “Data Classification: Amber”

Protected - This label applies encryption and a footer of “Data Classification: Amber”

Green

Unprotected - This label applies a footer of “Data Classification: Green”

Protected - This label applies encryption and a footer of “Data Classification: Green”

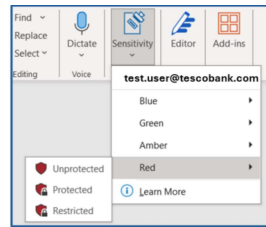
Blue

Unprotected - This label applies a footer of “Data Classification: Blue”

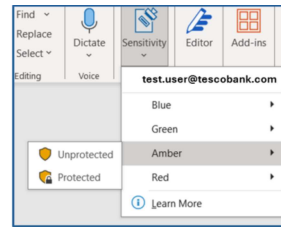
How to apply labels

Applying labels is very easy, and built into the familiar Microsoft Office application you use every day:

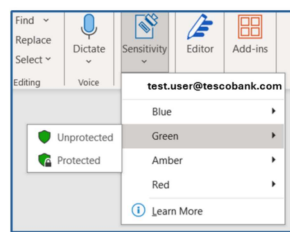
In an Office document (Word, Excel, PowerPoint) there is a sensitivity menu in the Office ribbon. It is simply a drop down that gives you the options to choose the appropriate information classification and label option:



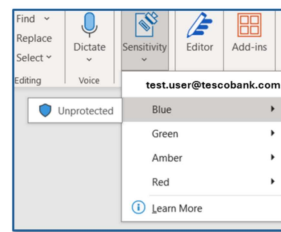
Red



Amber



Green



Blue

For Microsoft Outlook there is a sensitivity icon at the top of the email, again with a simple drop down menu:

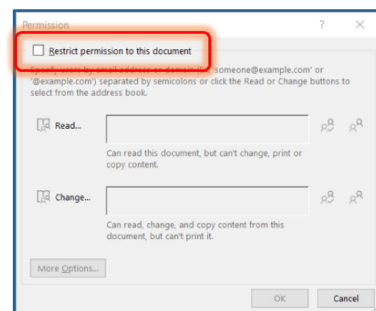
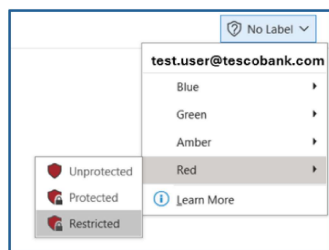
Applying the Red\Restricted label

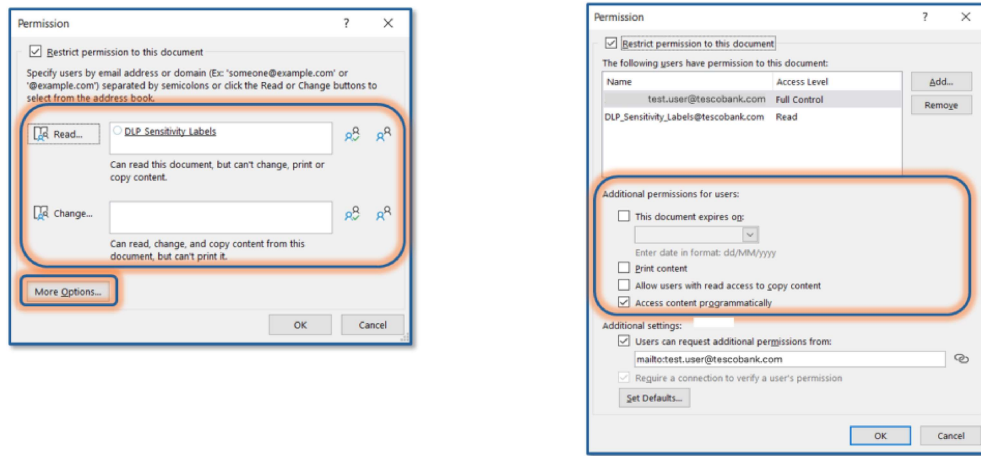
This label is for those rare occasions when you want to be very restrictive and prevent recipients from forwarding and printing emails or apply specific permissions on documents.

Special Categories of data (formerly called sensitive personal data) as defined by Data Protection Laws means personal data relating to racial or ethnic origin of the data subject, political opinions, religious beliefs or other beliefs of a similar nature, trade union membership, physical or mental health or condition, sexual life, sexual orientation, genetics, and biometrics where used for ID purposes. Information relating to criminal convictions is not considered a special category, however it does require safeguards as stated in article 10 of GDPR.

The behaviour is slightly different when applying to emails and documents.

When applying this label to documents colleagues are presented with the option to specify who can access the document and what permission they have (i.e. read only, edit). By default printing and copying are disabled, but these can be changed to allow this.





When applying this label to **emails** colleagues are not given any option to change the restrictions, these are configured in the background to only allow the recipients to read the email, and forwarding and printing are disabled.

Impact of applying the “Protected” labels

The Protected labels under Red, Amber, and Green classifications apply encryption to documents and emails. There are some challenges with this for some recipients and situations that colleagues need to be aware of.

1. Documents will be encrypted, which requires the recipient to have Microsoft Office to decrypt and read. If someone uses Google Docs for example, they will not be able to open the encrypted document.
2. Some systems such as Service Now need to be able to process documents to do something with them, which can be a problem if a document is encrypted and uploaded. Certain previews may also be affected, such as previews for Office files uploaded to Confluence.
3. Emails will also be encrypted, however unlike documents, if someone does not use Microsoft Office they are presented with a secure web client which would allow them to open the email. However, some businesses block access to encrypted emails for their own security policies which can interfere with this.

If any of the above scenarios, or combinations of the above are encountered this is where the “Unprotected” labels come in. Simply choose the appropriate information classification, then the “Unprotected” label for that classification and the document or email will only have the footer applied, not encryption.

NOTE: If you are sending/sharing sensitive information with an “Unprotected” label, you will need to appropriately secure the data by some other means such as password protection or enforced TLS (this is a mechanism to encrypt the transfer of email).

BARCLAYS COMMUNICATION: Enforced TLS is in place with Barclays, therefore emails sent to Barclays CAN use an “Unprotected” label.

External Recipient Experience

When you send an email to an external recipient there are two experiences depending on if the recipient is using a Microsoft based account or not. A Microsoft account includes other Microsoft 365 accounts, and Outlook.com accounts.

Microsoft Accounts

If the recipient is using a Microsoft account the experience is seamless and transparent, providing the same experience they would be used to.

Non-Microsoft Accounts

If the recipient is not using a Microsoft based account (personal accounts such as Gmail, Yahoo, BT Internet...), the experience will be slightly different. Recipients receive an email (see below screenshots). They are directed to a secure web portal by clicking on the “**Read the message**” box, where a 6 digit code is sent to their mailbox which gives them access to the message and attachments.



Once the 6-digit code has been entered, the recipient can see the message and attachments

Common Challenge Key words

[Service Now](#) | [Work & Pay](#) | [Power Automate](#) | [Power BI](#) | [Power Apps](#) | [Protected email access](#) | [Outlook Issues](#)

Common Challenges

Change, and the introduction of new technology and controls can cause friction and sometimes disruption until they become embedded. The Bank's technology and security teams have been working hard during the pilot phases of the roll out to work closely with colleagues, to understand the real life challenges, and to work together to find solutions that satisfy both the Bank's security obligations and colleagues' operational challenges. The below sections outline the majority of challenges experienced and how they can be approached.

Service Now, Work and Pay

Emailing or uploading documents to Service Now or Work & pay is not supported.

In some instances, automated systems that process documents, such as Service Now or Work and Pay, can't read a document or email that has a label that applies encryption.

Solution: In this scenario use the "unprotected" label for the appropriate information classification. This label does exactly what it says, it will still classify the data and add footers to the bottom of the document, but it will not be encrypted and can be used for those situations where encryption is not supported.

Power Platform, Power BI, Power Automate

I am trying to load some data from a document into a Power BI report or process using Power Automate and it is not working.

Power BI and Power Automate can have issues trying to load data from an Excel spreadsheet that are encrypted, including encryption provided by the "Protected" labels.

Solution: In this scenario use the "unprotected" label for the appropriate information classification. This label does exactly what it says, it will still classify the data and add footers to the bottom of the document, but it will not be encrypted and can be used for those situations where encryption is not supported.

We use Power Platform, such as Power Automate, to "scrape" a mailbox and process the email, but for some reason it is not working on emails protected with a label

At the moment Power Platform, including Power Automate can have issues trying to process email protected by a label.

Solution: In this scenario use the "unprotected" label for the appropriate information classification. This label does exactly what it says, it will still classify the data and add footers to the bottom of the document, but it will not be encrypted and can be used for those situations where encryption is not supported.

Outlook issues

When I click on an email that has a “protected” label applied, it can hang for several seconds before opening

Some older versions of Outlook cache information in a certain way that can cause several issues. We have found that changing to the New Outlook experience (the little toggle in the top right hand corner of Outlook) can improve this, and often just the process of moving to the new version, then back to the old version (if that is your preference) can resolve this issue.

I am unable to forward emails as an attachment - the body is blank

Older emails may be retaining previous permission settings that do not work with the sensitivity labels. To resolve this, download the email to your computer as a .msg file and open it directly in Outlook - forwarding this way allows the new sensitivity labels to be applied and the email to be sent.

I can't see the content of an email in the reading pane and have to double click to open and read messages

Some older versions of Outlook don't recognise that a colleague is authenticated, and requires opening the email to view the content. This isn't an issue in the new version of Outlook, which you can use if this is a problem. Some colleagues have found that temporarily switching to the new Outlook (the toggle at the top right of Outlook), and then reverting back to the old version of Outlook sometimes fixes the issue

Protected Email Access

I am trying to email someone, and they can't open the attachment.

In some instances, a recipient may not be able to open a document that is protected by a label that applies encryption.

Solution: In this scenario use the “unprotected” label for the appropriate information classification. This label does exactly what it says, it will still classify the data and add footers to the bottom of the document, but it will not be encrypted and can be used for those situations where encryption is not supported.

I am trying to email someone, and they can't open the email.

In some instances, a recipient will not be able to open an email that is protected by a label that applies encryption. This could be for several reasons, such as their IT systems blocking access to Microsoft URLs or similar.

Solution: In this scenario use the “unprotected” label for the appropriate information classification. This label does exactly what it says, it will still classify the data and add footers to the bottom of the document, but it will not be encrypted and can be used for those situations where encryption is not supported.

I am trying to email someone, and they can't open the email or open attachments.

There are some situations where a company does not support encryption at all, so the recipient will not be able to open both the email, and the attachments.

Solution: In this scenario use the “unprotected” label for the appropriate information classification. This label does exactly what it says, it will still classify the data and add footers to the bottom of the document, but it will not be encrypted and can be used for those situations where encryption is not supported.

I want to send personal data to myself

I want to send myself some personal information, to my personal email address and I don't know which label to use.

Solution: The first question you should ask yourself, regardless of the technical labels, is what classification is the data (Red, Amber, Green, Blue). If it is general HR/Payroll/Performance information this would probably be Amber. If it includes GDPR "special category data" (race, religion, sexual orientation etc.) it would probably be Red. Let's assume it is general data, and therefore Amber. The second question you should then ask is can the recipient system accept protected (i.e. encrypted) information. If you think they can then choose the "protected" label under Amber. If you don't think that they can accept protected data then choose the "unprotected" label under Amber.

Putting all that together in an example, let's say you are going to send yourself a document of your performance review, and you know you are going to send it to your Gmail account, and you also know that you don't have a copy of Microsoft Word on your personal laptop, you would do this:

1. Label the document of your performance review as "Amber\Unprotected" - because you don't have Microsoft Word on your personal laptop at home, you know you don't support the protection.
2. You would then attached that document to an email, and label the email as "Amber\Protected" because even though you don't have Microsoft Office at home, you don't need that to open a protected email because you will simply log into the Microsoft secure web portal using the link in the email you send (automatic in the background).

Using the above combination you can ensure your personal data is protected by the secure email, but you can also download the attachment at home, unprotected, and use as you see fit.

Password Protected zip files

Many colleagues will be familiar with the practice of using password protected zip files to share sensitive information. This method creates a few issues, such as how to transfer the password itself, remembering and properly documenting historic passwords and so on. Managing multiple password protected zip files creates a large management overhead for colleagues, and there is still the risk of transferring the password over an insecure method.

With the deployment of the "protected" labels colleagues can reduce the need to place documents in password protected zip files. For example if you classify an email or document as Amber/Protected it will be encrypted and secure and would not require password protecting.

NOTE: If you need to use the "Unprotected" labels you may still need to password protect the information.